

Chapter 8

Men Under a Cloud in "A Little Cloud"

If we imagine a first-time reading of "A Little Cloud"—rereading the story as though we had never read it before—we realize that for the first third of the story the narrator leaves us entirely adrift (like a 'little cloud?') as to certain significant issues of time and place. The opening paragraph strongly suggests that the protagonist has recently been reunited with an old friend he has not seen for eight years—"Eight years before he had seen his friend off at the North Wall and wished him godspeed. Gallaher had got on. You could tell that at once by his travelled air, his well-cut tweed suit and fearless accent" (70). We virtually "see" the protagonist sizing up the first impression the returned old friend has made on him—scrutinizing his air, suit, and accent. It isn't until many pages later, when Gallaher greets Chandler at Corless's ("Well, and how have you been pulling along since I saw you last? Dear God, how old we're getting" [74]) that we realize the reunion is taking place only then, and that Chandler's prior estimations and encomia of Gallaher had been entirely proleptic, future projections of the status of fantasy. That "well-cut tweed suit" the narration had let us "see" by rhetorically inviting us to watch Chandler lay eyes on it ("You could tell that at once by his travelled air, his well-cut tweed suit . . ." [70])—never materializes in fact and effectively doesn't exist. Whatever suit Gallaher wears at Corless's is entirely eclipsed by its sartorial opposite, a gaudy and politically incorrect "vivid orange tie" (75).

This tale of homosocial jousting for prestige and metaphysical mastery figures its sense of the insubstantiality of judgment and estimation as a "little cloud"¹—a sign or omen or signifier that is nothing in itself and yet can determine our sense of prospects, our moods, our emotional atmosphere. In this respect, we see two men "under a cloud," in ironic and illogical ways in "A Little Cloud." While it is Gallaher who left Dublin under a "cloud" of suspicion ("he had got mixed up in some shady affair" [72]), Gallaher manages to depress and dispirit his old "friend" during a single, very brief reunion eight years later. Why does this happen, we may ask, when Chandler's anticipated and revised estimate of his friend's success is so clearly largely phantasmal?² The Gallaher he meets at Corless's is "well-travelled" chiefly by having visited what Garry Leonard calls

“the more lurid tourist-traps” of such cities as London, Paris, and Berlin (154). The “fearless accent” Chandler expected to hear turns out to be crass and offensive—“Gallaher’s accent and way of expressing himself did not please him. There was something vulgar in his friend which he had not observed before” (77). And, in his heart, Chandler characterizes Gallaher’s “vagrant and triumphant life” as produced by a career of “mere tawdry journalism” (80) and the cultivation of cynically exploitive attitudes toward marriage and respectability (“I mean to marry money. She’ll have a good fat account at the bank or she won’t do for me” [81]). Sexually, Gallaher shamelessly presents himself as a species of male whore. Why then is Chandler defeated by Gallaher, and why do readers and critics, generally validate this defeat—in spite of Gallaher’s obvious vulgarity, dissolution, and sexual venality?

I believe that the answer resides in a highly perverse narrative manipulation that brings the problematic criteria of Dublin’s homosocial bonhomie into the story, and thereby tries to configure the reader (male or female) as a masculinist chauvinist. Gallaher appears to have spunk in the way Chandler does not—a judgment that Gallaher, Chandler, and the narrator accept in a tacit collusion that is extended to the reader. Yet our ability to discern that the norms of masculinity in this story are constructed in a strange, contradictory, and repulsive way should make us uneasy with both Gallaher’s and Chandler’s gender and sexual estimations of each other. That we both experience and ignore this unease, and follow the narrative prompts to think Gallaher more manly than Chandler, proceeds from a performative collusion of narration and readerly judgment. By looking critically at internalized values that translate into gender norms for the three major figures of the story—narrator, Gallaher, and Chandler—we can see how the reader is pressed both into complicity and into resistance by their construction. That construction is itself revealed as existentially unmoored and phantasmal—that is, being a “man” is produced not by a male’s actions or behavior but by largely negative subjective states—desires, fears, and envies—that produce masculinity (as Jacques Lacan has argued) under the sign of the threat.³ The complexity of the contradictory gender ideologies in the story is further complicated by the strange way sexual and social values are linked to estimations attached to various genres of writing and art. In one sense, the story might be read as a contest of the masculinity of not only the school-friends, Chandler and Gallaher, but of poetry and journalism as their respective arts of choice. If so, how does the story’s narrative language fare in this metaphysical contest of gender, genre, and prestige?

The narrator’s introduction of Thomas Chandler (who is never called that by the narrator even though he consistently refers to Gallagher by his byline, Ignatius Gallagher) predisposes the reader to patronize Chandler socially and in

gendered terms before he even becomes a dramatized figure in the story. As the anonymous pronominal "he" of the first paragraph, Chandler is first glimpsed purely relationally, as a Hegelian metaphysical slave, conferring respect, recognition, and homage on a phantasmal masterful Gallaher.⁴ In the next paragraph he is introduced as "Little Chandler" with the explanation that "he was called that" because although "but slightly under the average stature, he gave one the idea of being a little man" (70). By narrative admission, Chandler is not physically a small man, yet as evidence for this "idea" of him as "a small man," an inventory of physical traits is marshalled. While these are not in themselves effeminate (quiet voice, refined manners, fair silken hair and moustache, etc.), they are shaded with vaguely effeminate implications (fastidious grooming including a "discreetly" perfumed handkerchief, manicured nails, teeth characterized as "childish white teeth," etc.). This pre-judgmental, or prejudiced, diminution and infantilization of Chandler⁵ by the narrator is virtually impossible to dislodge or revise even when challenged by ensuing information and subsequent narrative events. The "little cloud" that shadows Thomas Chandler in the text is, among other things, the cloud of "littleness."

Thomas Chandler remains "Little Chandler" in the narrative discourse, even though Ignatius Gallaher calls him "Tommy," and we soon realize that in all probability he is called "Little Chandler" only behind his back and without his assent. In this way, narrator and reader become complicit in a patronizing form of unkind gossip about this man, and the "story" of "A Little Cloud" becomes an exercise in masculinist belittlement and sexual diminution. The ultimate power of that narrational epithet, which has no other corroboration within the story, is the extent to which it has infected critical discourse. Warren Beck, who produces one of the most complex and nuanced readings of the end of the story, nonetheless adopts the narrator's diminution of Chandler, and refers to him as "this little fellow" (163), a "little actor" (165), and likens him to "many a wavering little man" (175). Beck also echoes the implication of effeminacy that clings to the diminution, calling him "childish, effeminate Little Chandler" (176), and relegating him to a type of "femininely intensive fellow" (167). When Earl Ingersoll does the same, he nonetheless puts "feminized" in quotation marks, to signal the constructed sense of the designation (123).

To fully dilate the ironies of this story, we must explore the question of *why* the narrator would offer us a less flattering picture of Thomas Chandler than of Ignatius Gallaher. I find it useful to begin by looking at the narration of three situations in the story: Thomas Chandler alone in the city, Thomas Chandler with Ignatius Gallaher at Corless's, and Thomas Chandler in his own home. Thomas Chandler alone—at his desk in King's Inn on the afternoon of his meeting with Gallaher, or walking through Dublin on his way to Corless's—is

represented as a man beclouded with poetic desire. Poetry is both the end and means of Chandler's desire: he would like to see himself represented as harboring poetic sensibility, as a poetic figure, a man who transcends quotidian life by losing himself in the perception of beauty and of loss as transmogrified by aestheticized language. "He tried to weigh his soul to see if it was a poet's soul" (73), and judging that it might be, he gives himself a poetic name ("T. Malone Chandler" [74]) and mentally pens favorable reviews for the poetry he has yet to write ("*Mr Chandler has the gift of easy and graceful verse. . . . The Celtic note*" [74]). Clearly Thomas Chandler is here satirized as a poetaster, a *poet manqué*, an effete and solipsistic romanticist—perhaps enfolded in Joyce's greater critique of the Celtic revival's futile aesthetic escapism ("That they may dream their dreamy dreams / I carry off their filthy streams" [CW 151]). The reader is prompted to patronize Chandler's poetic desires and to view them as fatuous and jejune ("He was not sure what idea he wished to express but the thought that a poetic moment had touched him took life within him like an infant hope" [73]). Vincent Cheng gives us a nuanced political anatomy of Chandler's desires, noting, "What we have here is a culturally constructed desire for 'culture'—high culture in its Eurocentric cosmopolitan essence" (118). But even if Chandler looks to poetry chiefly for symbolic self-aggrandizement, his poetic fantasies could be construed as first symptoms of an anti-Philistinism, an inchoate resistance to bourgeois complacency with ambitions more internal and transcendent than crassly commercial or purely social.

The narrator goes to some pains to juxtapose Chandler's philosophical posturings ("Melancholy was the dominant note of his temperament, he thought, but it was a melancholy tempered by recurrences of faith and resignation and simple joy" [73]) with their patently unsuccessful poetic expressions. But this narrative maneuver is itself problematic. We are given a putative "sample" of Chandler's production of figuration that almost literally names his poetic experiment a *pathetic fallacy*: "he looked down the river towards the lower quays and pitied the poor stunted houses" [73]). The narrative discourse goes on to elaborate Chandler's pathos for the houses in richly detailed personification. "They seemed to him a band of tramps, huddled together along the riverbanks, their old coats covered with dust and soot, stupefied by the panorama of sunset and waiting for the first chill of night to bid them arise, shake themselves and begone" (73). One might almost be seduced by the arresting elegance of this image—pathetic fallacy or no—had the narrator not already undercut it by showing Chandler completely oblivious to the hordes of grimy children who actually live in such tenements—"He picked his way deftly through all that minute vermin-like life" (71). But the class-inflected denigration produced by the naturalism is here the narrator's—not Chandler's—since we know that "Lit-

tle Chandler gave them [the children] no thought" (71). Yet is Chandler's aesthetic tramp trope for the houses (faithfully reproduced by the narrator, we trust) necessarily inferior to this naturalism that transforms the children into squatting mice? At times, indeed, the poetic language of the story is indeterminate with respect to attribution⁶ and we can't be certain whether a metaphor is the narrator's or, by the operation of a kind of Uncle Charles Principle,⁷ a stylistic projection of Chandler's inauthentic desire to imitate a "Celtic note." Is it the narrator who rhetorically enacts the casting of an aesthetic spell, the production of "glamour" in its archaic sense, in the release of a shower of poetic fairy dust? The fairy dust is here poetic language that magically transforms a quotidian Dublin park into a pastoral scene—"The glow of a late autumn sunset covered the grass plots and walks. It cast a shower of kindly golden dust on the untidy nurses and decrepit old men who drowsed on the benches" (71)? Or is this language the poetic analogue of Chandler's spiritual ethos, his desire to cast poetic magic dust over his "sober, inartistic life" (73)?

When Chandler is described as approaching Corless's, the narrative language remains suspended between Chandler's fantasy and its own (possibly parodic) exhibitionism. In Chandler's imagination of the glamour promised by "the value of the name" of "Corless," he conjures up rumors and memories of elegant entertaining, dining, dress, and conveyance—oysters and liqueurs served by Continental waiters to gowned ladies in "noisy dresses and many wraps" alighting from cabs "escorted by cavaliers" (72). Is it the narrative voice or Chandler himself who produces the classical allusion in their description—"Their faces were powdered and they caught up their dresses, when they touched earth, like alarmed Atalantas" (72)? This prose is not bad, and the simile is provocative, if not clearly apt.⁸ The scene is scarcely the product of observation since Chandler passes it quickly and doesn't turn his head to look. It is therefore either Chandler's language of fantasy or its transliteration by the narrator that we hear. Are we, as readers, to be impressed by its erudition or irked by its pretension? The question is important because the treatment of Chandler's poetic desires implicates the narrative's poetic language. If we are meant to deride Chandler's poesy, does the story's own style become indicted for using aesthetics in the interest of social pretension and snobbery?

Curiously, Chandler's fantasies of Corless's are not substantiated by the narrative. Chandler's reverie of achieving poetic success so distracts him that he passes Corless's by and has to retrace his steps, and at the entrance, we catch no glimpse of cabs, ladies, cavaliers, or other indices of glamour. The Corless of his imagination is shown to be as phantasmal as the Gallaher of his imagination. Once inside Chandler suffers a curious hallucination of the critical gaze—imagining that everyone stops to begin "observing him curiously" (74), a mistake

he corrects “when his sight cleared a little” and he realizes that “nobody had turned to look at him” (74). The exposure of this moment of acute self-consciousness heightens our sense of Chandler’s insecurity and lack of confidence—and yet the narration’s unkind and belittling scrutiny of him enacts the very gaze he fears and fantasizes. Neither Corless nor Gallaher live up to Chandler’s glamorous expectations. He will end up having a few drinks at a bright and noisy bar with an overbearing and seedy braggart he comes to disrespect sufficiently that all envy should reasonably have been allayed. Afterwards, Chandler should have gone home disillusioned and thankful for his bourgeois life. The reader’s estimation should have mirrored this correction in response to a revised narrative estimate that Chandler is worth more as a man and as a human being than Gallaher. Given what we see of their exchange, the encounter of the two men at Corless’s should have produced a narrative and readerly education in sexual and gender values that should have transformed the narrative into a didactic feminist exemplum.⁹

When Chandler at last catches sight of Gallaher in actuality, the narrative immediately abets his disillusionment by drawing attention not to a look of prosperity of the kind Chandler had fantasized earlier in the day, but to his thinning hair and the “unhealthy pallor” (75) of his face. The “vivid orange tie” eclipses the suit that Chandler had imagined as a “well-cut tweed” (70). And—importantly—Gallaher says nothing about his journalistic triumphs and instead deflates any glamour in his profession: “It pulls you down. . . . Press life. Always hurry and scurry, looking for copy and sometimes not finding it: and then always to have something new in your stuff. Damn proofs and printers, I say, for a few days” (75). Gallaher says nothing to fuel Chandler’s fantasies of the romance of writing, and Chandler is given no encouragement to pursue the conversation about the possibilities of a writing career. As a result, Chandler never brings up his scheme of adopting a poetic name (“He would speak to Gallaher about it” [74]), or asking Gallaher if he “might be able to get it [his poetry] into some London paper for him” (73). Instead, their reminiscences about the successes and failures of various school chums quickly snag on the topic of sexual knowledge and experience, and remain hooked there for the duration of their encounter. The recrudescence of this adolescent preoccupation produces a psychological and discursive regression in both figures toward which the narrative voice remains noncommittal in a way that ultimately works to Chandler’s disadvantage.

How this disadvantage is produced becomes clear only in retrospect, when toward the latter part of the story we realize that there are things about both Gallaher and Chandler that the narrator has deliberately withheld from us. Their conversation at Corless’s veers off in the direction of the sexual and the

immoral when Chandler hints that their friend O'Hara has "gone to the dogs" not only on account of "boose," as Gallaher proposes, but as Chandler hints, on account of "[o]ther things, too" (76). Gallaher immediately uses this hint of illicit knowledge to twit Chandler about his probity ("You're the very same serious person that used to lecture me on Sunday mornings when I had a sore head and a fur on my tongue" [76]) and thereby reinforces the narrator's prior infantilization of Chandler. Yet Chandler knows more, and has more sexual curiosity and experience than Gallaher suspects or the narrator has been willing to reveal. We now recall the earlier narrative disclosure that "whenever he found himself in the city late at night," Chandler courts "the causes of his fear" by walking in the darkest, narrowest lanes animated by "wandering, silent figures" and "low furtive laughter" (72). Retrospectively it becomes clear that the narrator had declined to explore this passage, to explain why a man who "punctiliously" leaves his job every day "when his hour had struck" (71) finds himself walking in the city late at night. Nothing precludes the possibility that those dark and narrow streets may be, as Garry Leonard reasonably surmises, "those frequented by prostitutes" (150). Leonard supposes that Chandler would not respond to their solicitations. However, I would suggest that this confidence is produced by the narrator's and Gallaher's deliberate efforts to shape Chandler into an innocent and virginal figure.

During Chandler's and Gallaher's conversation at Corless's we might expect the anticipated gender structure that figures Gallaher as a sexually experienced and worldly roué and Chandler as an innocent and provincial naïf to become reversed. One should be able to hear in Gallaher's boastings and exaggerations the marks of their gender opposite—masculinity as a masquerade of certain fictions and clichés drawn from low and disreputable cultural genres, offered as a simulacrum that betrays the paucity of the real thing. What confounds this readerly perception, however, is the narrator's interference in the gender dialectic by working resolutely on the side of Gallaher. While the narrative voice undermines Chandler, only Gallaher's theatrical performance—unaided by the narrator—gives him away. Gallaher betrays in his own boastful dialogue the superficial and probably spurious nature of his experience and knowledge. For example, he is obliged to produce a telling correction, "Talk of immorality! I've heard of cases—what am I saying?—I've known them: cases of . . . immorality" (78), and the concession that he reports second hand gossip—"Some things he could not vouch for (his friends had told him), but of others he had personal experience" (78). It is difficult to see just how Gallaher would have personal knowledge "with details" of the scandal of the English duchess ("which he knew to be true") or the secrets of the religious houses on the Continent. In *Ulysses* a clever Gallaher is identified as working for Alfred C.

Harmsworth, a publisher of two London papers but also a purveyor of sensational popular literature.¹⁰ Gallaher is therefore likely to have been no stranger to contemporary tabloid journalism or Victorian pornography, likely sources for the kind of scabrous fare he dishes up for an “astonished” Chandler.

Almost immediately after this recital, which has Chandler’s astonishment cast him again as a sexual novice, Gallaher himself produces a biographical fact that the narrator barely glanced earlier, and then only as a negative: that Chandler is married and has a child. By having Chandler blush before each confirmation of wife and child (“Little Chandler blushed again. ‘We have one child,’ he said” [79]), the narrative continues to intensify his virginal image at the very moment it produces evidence to the contrary. The narrator further colludes with Gallaher’s insulting tribute—“‘Bravo,’ he said, ‘I wouldn’t doubt you, Tommy’ ” (79) by showing Chandler looking “confusedly at his glass” and biting “his lower lip with three childishly white front teeth” (79). At the very moment both the narrator and Gallaher must concede Chandler’s adulthood, his consummated marriage and paternity, both specifically demean his masculinity by expressing surprise through denial (“I wouldn’t doubt you”) and representing him as infantilized as an embarrassed child. The reader is, of course, prompted to accept Gallaher’s implicit estimation of Chandler as an improbable man. But it is important to remember that the semiology of the blush is finally indeterminate. Chandler could have blushed for any number of reasons (“A trifle made him blush at any time” [80]) besides being embarrassed by mention of his marital and parental status. His blush might as easily signify pride or satisfaction. This entire exchange between Gallaher and Chandler is externalized, and reflects nothing of Chandler’s thoughts or feelings.

What does follow this exchange is a reversal of roles to which, I believe, the narrator scarcely does justice. Chandler for the first time puts forth a self-representation to his friend of his own civilized, settled, socially established life as a paterfamilias with a home: “‘I hope you’ll spend an evening with us,’ he said, ‘before you go back. My wife will be delighted to meet you. We can have a little music, and—’” (79). Gallaher rebuffs this polite invitation even before it is completely uttered—and even when Chandler is willing to accommodate his friend’s pressed schedule by moving it forward to that very evening. The interpretation prompted by both narrator and Chandler of this refusal is the one that Chandler later articulates to himself—“He saw behind Gallaher’s refusal of his invitation. Gallaher was only patronising him by his friendliness just as he was patronising Ireland by his visit” (80). But Gallaher’s sudden desire to break away and hurry off to his card game has other possible explanations that neither Chandler nor the narrator consider. The reunited friends never discuss the shady affair that forced Gallaher to depart Ireland under a cloud sufficiently

threatening to prevent him from returning for eight years even though he was just across the channel. The question of Gallaher's expatriation, with its hints of scandal and possible criminality, could too easily come up in an evening's reminiscences with the wife at the Chandler home. Alternatively, Gallaher might fear an uncomfortable turning of the tables, that the sight of Chandler's young family in their tidy home amid domestic comfort could highlight his own "vagrant" and sordid existence, his own permanent entrapment in a morally pimply and aimless adolescence.

Yet Chandler effectively takes control during the remainder of the scene at Corless's, insisting on a last round of drinks, acknowledging to himself that he is better bred and better educated than Gallaher, and insisting that Gallaher too will settle down to domestic life before too long. Garry Leonard is one of the few critics who have appreciated Chandler's cleverness in this scene ("I might add, the quality of his conversational strategy with Gallaher is underappreciated—perhaps because his later collapse at home is so abject" [157]), which flushes out a possibly defensive and increasingly repulsive Gallaher. Warren Beck too feels that at the end of their meeting, Chandler "positively takes his own position" (177). The whole discussion of marriage should have vindicated Chandler—in the reader's eyes as well as his own—were it not for a narrative undercutting of his initiatives. The narrator refocuses our attention on his blush, points out that small whiskeys and cigar have fuddled Chandler because "he was a delicate and abstinent person," and lets us know that the effect of "sharing Gallaher's vagrant and triumphant life, upset the equipoise of his delicate nature" (80). At the very moment Chandler asserts himself against Gallaher by displaying his own signifiers of manliness and holding his ground, the narrator resolutely reinfantilizes him by showing him blushing, delicate, and sensitive, and by using the code of the "abstinent" to desexualize him once again. Gallaher's defense against Chandler's bold toast to a proleptic marriage for "Mr and Mrs Ignatius Gallaher" (81) is to first demean the institution as putting one's "head in the sack," and then to strip it of both romance and respectability by treating it as a species of prostitution ("There are hundreds—what am I saying?—thousands of rich Germans and Jews, rotten with money, that'd be only too glad" [81]). Gallaher's final thrust, aimed directly at Chandler's connubial sexuality, is to treat marital sex as an unpleasant taste in the mouth. With an utterly coarse and insulting oral gesture, he strips any final value or charm from Chandler's young married estate. "He imitated with his mouth the act of tasting and made a wry face. —Must get a bit stale, I should think, he said" (82).

The resistant reader longs to have this break in the evening, and in the narrative, followed by Chandler's angry revision of his earlier flattering expectations of his old friend's success, and by his repudiation of what has become a

patently worthless friendship. Yet the shocking denouement of the story is Gallaher's inexplicable victory. For Chandler returns to his home with Gallaher's despicable values now internalized ("he does swallow Gallaher's line," Kershner says [99]) and trains them upon his family and his domestic life. That these values have also been narrational values with a significant impact on the reader, can be seen in an analysis like Suzette Henke's, which more than most extends the diminution and unsexing of Thomas Chandler into his familial role. Henke's reading of the Chandler marriage transforms his "childlike and helpless" nature into the cause of "a pathological relationship of Oedipal dependency" with his wife (31). Annie, in turn, is seen as "reducing her immature consort to infantile status" and then displacing this "impotent father" with her infant son (31). Henke's reading is perfectly reasonable and consistent with the narrative prompts. With the help of a complicit narrator, Gallaher has indeed managed to proliferate his castrative innuendos about his old friend into the readerly and critical realm. But I find in Garry Leonard's resistance to the narrative promptings of this final scene in the story a significant alternative for exploring the instability of the story's narrative outcome. Leonard doesn't believe that Annie Chandler would not have listened to her husband's poetry, nor that the glances of hatred exchanged by the couple are permanent (168–69). Reading against the narrative cues makes some resistance to the reader's narrative complicity possible.

The curious tension in the narration of the final scene is raised by the discrepancy between the realistic representations of an attractive, well-run home and family life, and the cynical and disaffected shadow or *cloud* cast on it by Chandler's eyes as they are newly infected by Gallaher's libertine filter. Remembering the distortions the specter of Gallaher has earlier wrought on Chandler's perception of his surroundings—"For the first time his soul revolted against the dull inelegance of Capel Street" (73)—we now see this demeaning perspective imported into his home. Chandler's home is a place of thrift and mortgages,¹¹ to be sure, but with pretty furniture and extended family support, the young couple appears to have made successful adjustments to the emotional and domestic exigencies of marriage. The only ominous signals are Chandler's nocturnal wanderings, and his putative lack of thought of wife and child on this reported afternoon and evening—although this could be a temporary amnesia readily explained by his distraction by Gallaher on this particular day. Is the Gallaher filter that turns his wife's pretty eyes and his pretty furniture "mean" a temporary and provisional cloud—a *little* cloud—over the marriage? The passion and rapture he finds missing in Annie's eyes is so patently Gallaher's orientaling overlay ("He thought of what Gallaher had said about rich Jewesses" [83]). Or are we to take it as having produced an epiphany, a revelation of Chan-

dler's true spiritual state of affairs, as the narrator prods us to believe? Chandler's jaundiced reaction to the photo is certainly colored by Annie's snit at his late and empty-handed return from the office. And his cold "Hm! . . ." (83) shows him refusing to soften at the memory of the gift of the pale blue summer blouse she wears in the picture. Yet this memory nonetheless opens the narrative into a rare glimpse at the complex romantic and domestic negotiations of newly-weds. The recollection produces a small short story: Chandler's thrilled and nervous purchase of the blouse, Annie's delight at the surprise followed by angry dismay at the price, her inadvertently hurtful words and gestures, her attempts to make up with kisses and thanks. In the end, her affection for the blouse—now embedded with a complex marital history—is memorialized by her wearing it in the photograph. The entire little drama of the blouse reveals degrees of romance, delight, intimacy, difficulty, and accommodation in the Chandler marriage that are undreamt in Gallaher's swinish philosophy.

Chandler's contemplation of his home and his wife's picture could have been presented in myriad moods at many alternate moments, and it is clear that Chandler's story could have been told on a sunnier day than this particular one, without Gallaher's cloudy shadow oppressively leaching its color and warmth. As Leonard points out, "in reviling his wife's expression because he finds it insufficiently supportive of himself, he is simply doing to her what Gallaher has just finished doing to him" (165). Warren Beck concurs that Chandler robs himself of his earned domestic joy by letting himself be "foolishly unsettled by Gallaher's transit of his horizon" (179). Gallaher's transit further upsets the couple's routine on this particular day, when Annie's sister Monica is no longer on hand to run an errand to the corner store or hold a sleeping child who might wake up if he were put down. Chandler is consequently physically entrained in domestic confinements on the evening he is least conditioned to tolerate them.¹² The contretemps that results from his efforts to escape them intellectually—by reading the opening poem of Byron's 1807 *Hours of Idleness*—creates an ironic juxtaposition between life and poetry that tries to indict the fatuousness of Chandler's poetic melancholy even more cruelly than had the earlier narration. We do briefly note a curious narrative discrepancy, when we are told, "A volume of Byron's poems lay before him on the table" (83). The opening narration had quite definitely told us that Chandler never took the books on his shelves down to read them. "He had bought them in his bachelor days and many an evening, as he sat in the little room off the hall, he had been tempted to take one down from the bookshelf and read out something to his wife. But shyness had always held him back; and so the books had remained on their shelves" (71). How did the book get off the shelf? There is no mention that he takes it down between the opening of the section—"Little Chandler sat in the room off the hall, holding

a child in his arms" (82)—and the moment when he finds that "A volume of Byron's poems lay before him on the table" (83). Either Chandler's memory, or the narrator's, has exaggerated his shyness, for the books seem to circulate more than they have let on. The contretemps occurs when Chandler's reading of the poet's elegy for the dead girl is interrupted by a brush with real infant mortality. The crying of Chandler's infant is escalated into near convulsions by his shouting in the child's face to "Stop!" (84). Joyce produces here a violent clash of literary genres, as the Romantic elegy is irrupted and mimicked by naturalism.

In their resistances to the narrative prompts to read "A Little Cloud" as "one more story of a Dubliner circumstantially restrained from escape into a larger life" (Beck 179), Leonard and Beck remind us that smug complacencies and foolish escapisms form the dialectical dilemma of every Dubliner. Indeed, the pressure to decide between resignation and resistance to one's lot in life may be the dialectical dilemma that defines the bourgeois condition. The famous problem of Dublin *paralysis* may therefore be a model for a much more universal problem of making life choices in a nonutopian state. What "A Little Cloud" dramatizes both thematically and performatively is the role that projection, fantasy, and ideology can play in shaping the perception applied to these choices—and particularly the role played by gender ideology, as I have tried to show. The narrator of the story, I have been suggesting, is in one respect a double of Gallaher, a voice of belittlement and disparagement that colors our reading and interpretation of a story about a man's internalization of the belittlement and disparagement to which he is subjected on one evening. The curious twist, however, is that of style. In replicating the dirty work of Gallaher in aggrandizing itself at Chandler's expense, the narrative voice resorts not to the naturalism of Gallaher's literary medium, journalism, but chiefly to the aesthetic and poetic diction of Chandler's desire. Is the narration of "A Little Cloud" a projection of Chandler as Gallaher sees him or as Chandler sees himself through Gallaher's eyes? Or is the narration of "A Little Cloud" a melancholy Celtic version of Chandler's little (that is, insignificant) life clouded by a little (that is, insignificant) sadness on one particular day? Could Chandler's "It's nothing, Annie . . . it's nothing. . . . He began to cry" (85) apply as well to Chandler's "tears of remorse" at the end of the story? Has it all been just "a little cloud" that momentarily shadows people who are otherwise all right. "But wherefore weep?" as Byron's poem would say (Gifford 72).

Where does all this leave the reader? The problems created by the power of pre-judgment, by prejudice, by projection, by the warping of perception by desire—these are all dangers to which the reader of "A Little Cloud" is made vulnerable by the narrative voice and its various inflections. I earlier suggested that the narrator *tries* to construct the reader as a masculinist chauvinist. I

would now propose that it is his *style* of narration that prevents him from succeeding entirely. By telling the story in the poetic language of Chandler's desire, the narrative shapes the reader by story's end more into a Chandler who has internalized Gallaher's values, than a Gallaher who disdains a Chandler. We are induced to give Gallaher more ambivalent respect than we do Chandler, even as we are seduced by the poetic prose of Chandler's own cultural fantasies. Perhaps we have been led into this arena of insubstantial judgment and estimation of manhood and art by a narrative voice that could itself be characterized as "shy" or embarrassed about the "effeminacies" of its own aesthetic impulses. Perhaps it is this problematic imbrication or intermeshing of a theme, by which we are led to respect brash and robust journalists more than sensitive daydreamers, with its conveyance by an aesthetic poetic form that undermines just this judgment, that produces the reader's uneasiness and vacillations. In the end, the reader too is under "a little cloud," as we emerge from our experience of uncertain judgments and evaluations of manhood and art by recognizing that values and norms—particularly those of gender—are constructed phantasmally out of words.